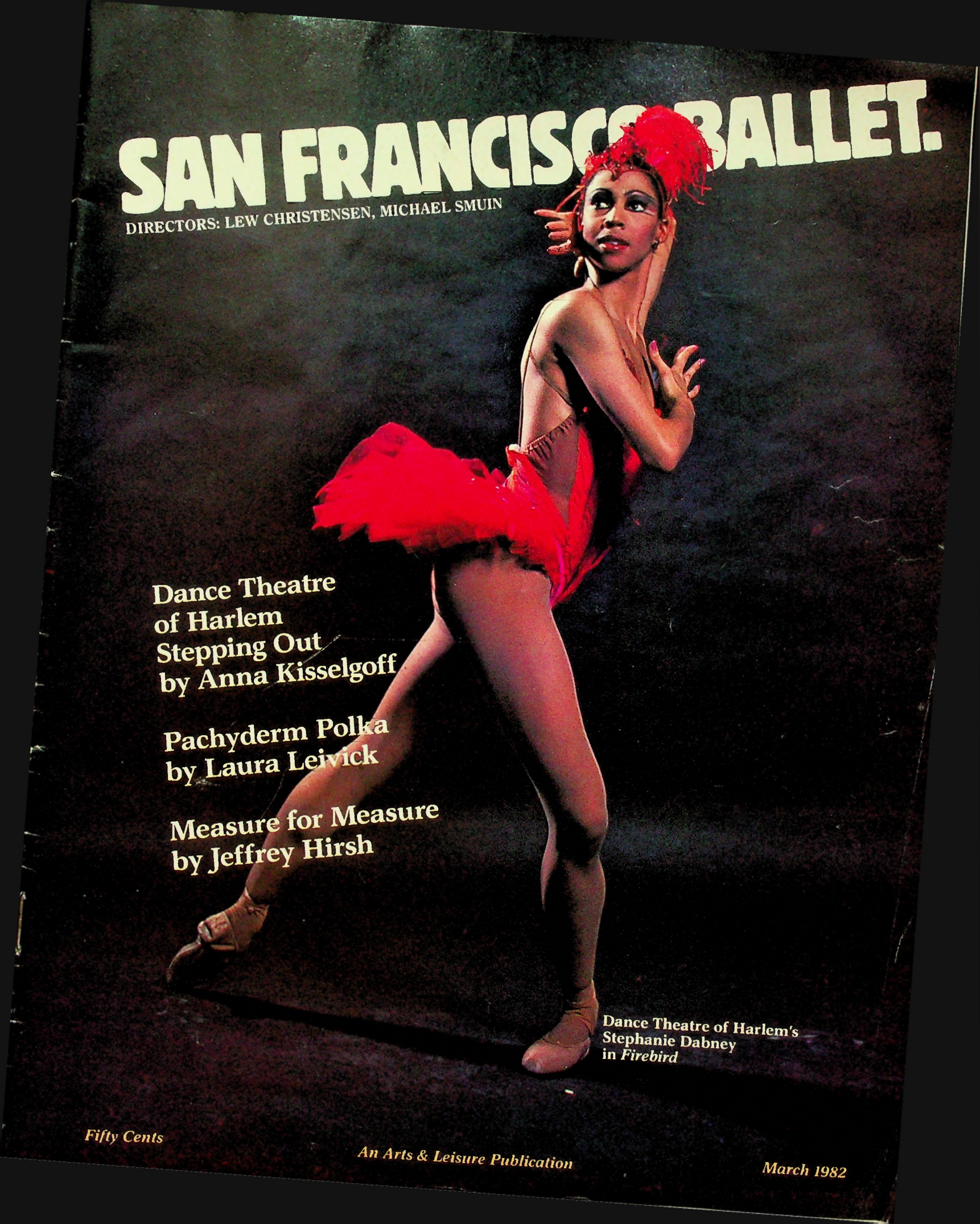
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Dance Theatre
of Harlem
Stepping Out
by Anna Kisselgoff

Pachyderm Polka
by Laura Leivick

Measure for Measure
by Jeffrey Hirsh

Dance Theatre of Harlem's
Stephanie Dabney
in *Firebird*

Fifty Cents

An Arts & Leisure Publication

March 1982

Stepping Out

Dance Theatre of Harlem has become an interracial company in a better position than ever to forge its own artistic profile.

by Anna Kisselgoff



Quite suddenly, a still young and very special company is on the threshold of another American success story. In its current season at the New York City Center, the Dance Theatre of Harlem has visibly taken a dramatic turn — in more ways than one. For the first time, it has emphasized dance-dramas over neo-classical plotless ballets among its premieres. In doing so, it has proclaimed a pronounced shift in its artistic policy.

The company may never abandon the heritage of George Balanchine ballets with which it began — a legacy reflected in its production of *Serenade*, with its diagonal of dancers unreeling so beautifully this year. But it appears that in the 1980s, Dance Theatre of Harlem will also be associated with new dramatic images — such as Lowell Smith as Stanley Kowalski in red silk pajamas pursuing his Blanche du Bois along a quite different diagonal in Valerie Bettis' *A Streetcar Named Desire*.

For the first time as well, the already acclaimed ensemble style of DTH, as it is known, is studded by unusually strong individual performances. A no-star company in the best ensemble spirit, DTH has pushed its principals a little more in relief this season. The result is that one should go see John Taras' new version of *Firebird* not only because it is a lively and fluent re-interpretation but because Stephanie Dabney streaks through the title role like lightning. It is Mr. Smith, a he-man of a physical presence with just the most subtle of dramatic characterizations, whom one should run to see in *Streetcar*.

It is Donald Williams' extraordinary pelvis-popping virtuoso turn — strangely mystical and erotic — as a voo-doo god that makes Geoffrey Holder's *Banda* so sensational. And it is Mr. Williams again, snorting and stomping as the best-known human horse in Anglo-American drama, who steals the show in Domy Reiter-Soffer's *Equus: The Ballet*. And Virginia Johnson should be singled out for her ability to hold the stage with such filigreed beauty in the difficult solo format of Mr. Holder's *Songs of the Auvergne*. At this rate, one can hope for the same star-level performances from the company's New York premiere of *Frankie and Johnny*, the 1938 Ruth Page-Bentley Stone Americana classic not yet seen at this writing.

Amid all the praise there is the realization that these superb individual performances have taken place in less than great works, some of which are fine on their own level. Mr. Holder, who also designed the sets and costumes for the Taras *Firebird*, is a dazzler as a showman and never lets his audience down in the spectacle category. Yet a good show — which is what the rest of the works offer as well — is not the same as a masterpiece.

This season, DTH has danced the 1946 Balanchine masterpiece *The Four Temperaments* less well than it has performed the premieres. It has, however, for the first time, given the greatest of all Balanchine ballets, *Concerto Barocco*, more nearly the performance it deserves. Moving from its initial careful treatment of *Serenade*, of several years ago, it has given a very fine, more emotional reading of another seminal Balanchine work. It has, of course, always danced *Allegro Brillante* as superbly as Mr. Balanchine's New York City Ballet.

Yet, the point made so emphatically this season is that the Dance Theatre of Harlem is not the New York City Ballet. The idea that DTH would be a black

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New York City Ballet has always rankled with the company's directors, Arthur Mitchell and Karel Shook.

It was natural for Mr. Mitchell, once one of the City Ballet's best known principal dancers, to turn to the Balanchine repertory as a model and base. It gave the company he founded in 1969 an instant treasure house of great ballets and it also allowed him to define the classical style in which he would train his dancers. The style is less visible among the men, but the silhouette of the DTH women — extended and stretched — owes more to the neo-classical style of the City Ballet than to textbook silhouettes found in other ballet companies.

Along with the Balanchine legacy, Mr. Mitchell included disparate ballets particularly suited to young emerging dancers and a category of dance works that drew upon the black heritage.

It was, frankly, this "black" aspect that made DTH different from other eclectic companies. Yet in retrospect it is now clear that DTH — when called eclectic — was not really eclectic in the true sense. It was still tied to two dominant strains in the Balanchine and black heritage repertories. This meant that a wide choice of dance traditions remained untapped. Therefore, the repertory problem DTH shared with most ballet companies was particularly acute.

Three years ago Mr. Mitchell and Mr. Shook suddenly turned toward a series of least expected revivals. If Mr. Mitchell is a City Ballet alumnus, Mr. Shook is a Ballet Russe de Monte Carlo graduate. A new family tree — Mr. Shook's — immediately provided the company with Ballet Russe stagings of *Scheherazade*, *Paquita*, and a one-act *Swan Lake*.

By last year, DTH was defined into five stylistic compartments: The Balanchine ballets and other neo-classical ballets in the same lineage by Mr. Mitchell and Mr. Taras; a few showpiece excerpts from the 19th century classics; the Ballet Russe de Monte Carlo revivals; contemporary works such as those by Glen Tetley that use modern dance and ballet; the black heritage pieces. In these circumstances, one could view DTH as either losing its identity or finding it.

Not only had the repertory changed but so had the skin color of some of its dancers. In recent seasons, more and more non-black dancers have been introduced into the ranks. The idea that black dancers can dance the neo-classical repertory is now fully established in the public's mind and Mr. Mitchell has decided to take it from there.

In fact, DTH has become an interracial company in a better position than ever to forge its own distinctive artistic profile. With the emphasis on plotless ballet in most troupes, DTH's turn toward overtly dramatic works makes it a company with a difference. Now that American Ballet Theater, increasingly drawn to loosely dramatic pieces, plotless ballets and 19th century classics, is no longer the prime purveyor of contemporary dramatic ballets, DTH may well assume the role Ballet Theater once played to such distinction. To say DTH is becoming less like City Ballet and more like ABT is not quite the point — which is that DTH is a mix of two traditions now merging into its own.

One element in this profile, as Mr. Mitchell rightly stresses, is that the company is mainly made up of Americans. Although some DTH dancers started ballet elsewhere, most were formed under Mr. Mitchell's and Mr. Shook's tutelage. They did not have the luxury of employing the complement of superbly finished Danish dancers that filled up the City Ballet's top male ranks or the Russian super-stars at Ballet Theater. Nor do they have the American dancers trained in other companies who flock to those two companies. As an aside, it might be mentioned that the loyalty of DTH's own principals has not exactly been of the bedrock variety. It has lost three of its top male dancers — Paul Russell, first to Scottish Ballet and now San Francisco Ballet, Ronald Perry to Ballet Theater and Mel Tomlinson to City Ballet.

The unaskable question is why these dancers prefer "white" companies to DTH. And the answer may be not these companies' whiteness but the standard of their artistry and the nature of their repertory. It is now clear to Mr. Mitchell that he cannot simply train dancers like Mr. Perry and Mr. Tomlinson just to lose them. They would not be in ABT and City Ballet without the preparation Mr. Mitchell gave them. To keep its dancers at home, DTH may well have to be the company non-black dancers want to join now that it is open to them. This is, in fact, already the case. This season, Joseph Cipolla, a white dancer whose crisp style has already been visible in the corps, did very well with his first leading roles.

None of the company premieres is unflawed, but all have truly exciting moments. *Equus: The Ballet*, by the Israeli choreographer, Domy Reiter-Soffer, was originally given by the Maryland Ballet in 1980. Its weak point is the hackneyed rendering of the realistic episodes in Peter Shaffer's play in contrast to the symbolic treatment of the young hero's trauma. Some contrast is deliberate. But the ordinariness is too ordinary (as in the psychiatrist's office scenes with the boy, and the character sketches of repressed parents) while the orgiastic fantasy (expressed in the disturbed Alan's identification with horses) is a highly imaginative vision scene.

continued on p. 40

Running Start

"It is a rule of thumb in this business," says Assistant Director Robert Gladstein, "that it takes a dancer a full year to adjust to a company. Our Apprentice program gives the student a year's running start."

by Laura Leivick



Celia Fushille, Carleton Gillenwater, Vantania Peltzer, Catherine Batcheller, and Ricardo Bustamante. photo: Marty Sohl

One of San Francisco Ballet's most successful programs is its smallest: the Apprentice program, which has only five participants per year. The apprentices, who are almost always chosen from SFB School's top classes, are limited to five by special agreement with the dancers' union, the Associated Guild of Musical Artists. AGMA also limits each apprentice to a single, one-year term; the year is spent in advanced studies as well as rehearsing and performing with the Company. At the end of the year, the young dancer is either offered a company contract or simply released.

"Of course you hope you'll get into the Company," says one apprentice, "so it's a little like waiting for a time-bomb to go off."

In fact, the one-year limit is for the apprentice's own protection. "An apprenticeship," says SFB Assistant Director Robert Gladstein firmly, "is on-the-job training. Since it is a training program, the base pay during the Season is half the rate for a new Company member, with full pay and per diem on tour. Without the time-limits we have set, apprentices might just be underpaid Company members. And young dancers need to know whether we want to make a full commitment to them, so that they can move on."

Apprentice contracts are signed with SFB's general manager each fall, just like Company contracts, but ties with the School remain strong. The Company directors observe advanced school classes during the summer, and make their selections in consultation with School Director Richard Cammack.

"When Mr. Cammack told me I got my apprenticeship," says Kristine Peary, who this year is a full Company member, "he said I would still be taking school classes. I had been studying here for six or seven years, and even though I was excited to be making a change, I thought it would be great. Then he said, 'be sure to work hard and have fun.' At first, being an apprentice wasn't that different from being in Class 8 in the School, except we got all our shoes free and the pay was better than the School scholarship and subsistence program. The Company rehearsal and performance schedule got harder and more interesting. The next thing I knew, the apprenticeship wasn't so exciting — I started worrying about getting a Company contract."

Both Company and School are very sensitive to the ambitions and anxieties of apprentices. "It is a rule of thumb in this business," says Gladstein, "that it takes a dancer a full year to adjust to a company. Even a professional dancer who moves from one company to another needs time to get his bearings. It happened to me when I changed from SFB to American Ballet Theatre for a while. You need time to get to know the other dancers, learn the repertory, and get a realistic picture of your value to the company.

"Our Apprentice program gives the student a year's running start. They spend a year learning to be part of the professional adult work force, to maximize their chances of successfully adapting to a career here or wherever

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Morris Gaines James Goree Charmaine Hunter Carld Jonassaint Stephanie Turner
Theara Ward Laurie Woodard Leslie Woodard

Serenade

Choreography: George Balanchine
Music: Peter Tchaikovsky
Staged for DTH by Victoria Simon
Costume Design: Karinska
Costume Execution: Clarke W. Thornton

Set to Tchaikovsky's *Serenade for Strings*, this was the first ballet created by Balanchine in America. It was originally presented on June 9, 1934 by the students of the School of American Ballet at the estate of Felix M. Warburg, White Plains, New York. Subsequently, the work was remounted for the American Ballet Caravan, 1941, the Ballet Russe de Monte Carlo, 1943, for the Grand Opera, Paris, 1947 and for the New York City Ballet, 1949. It has since gone into the repertories of several companies in this country and Europe.

Equus: The Ballet

(Company Premiere January 21, 1982)

Based on the play by Peter Shaffer

Directed, Choreographed and Designed by Domy Reiter-Soffer
**Music Composed by* Wilfred Josephs
Costumes Executed by
E. Huntington Parker Costume Shop
Lighting: Clarke W. Thornton

The main action of the ballet takes place in a psychiatric hospital, the Strang Family home, a stable and a field at night. The ballet is divided into scenes, indicating a change of time, locale or mood.

At the heart of this drama is a crime: For no apparent reason, the 17 year old Alan Strang has blinded six horses. Instead of sending the stable boy to jail, magistrate Hesther Salomon brings him to child psychiatrist Martin Dysart. Trying to learn Alan's motives, he discovers the conflict that consumes his uncooperative patient, who struggles against his teenage sexual longings, his mother's religious fanaticism, and his father's brusque atheism. Alan, who yearns for love and fulfillment has invested horses with magical, god-like powers. His special favorite and object of worship and desire is Nugget.

It is Jill, the groom, who has introduced Alan to her world and she now wants him to make love to her in the stable. But Alan cannot respond; he cannot risk an act of love in the presence of the watching "horse-gods," for fear of being severely punished.

After discharging Alan, Martin realizes that during the process of Alan's treatment he discovered his own *normal* life is barren, devoid of ecstasy, magic, religious fervor and love in comparison to his patient's rich and fanciful madness.

*By arrangement with Belwin-Mills Publishing Corp., New York, publishers and copyright owner.

This production was partially funded by a grant from the National Endowment for the Arts.

"Equus: The Ballet" is produced by permission of Peter Shaffer and his agent, Robert Lantz of the Lantz Office, Inc., 114 E. 55th St., New York City.

Domy Reiter-Soffer is represented exclusively by Dube Zakin Management, Inc., 1841 Broadway, New York City.

Dr. Wilfred Josephs is represented by Belwin-Mills.

Firebird

(World Premiere January 12, 1982)

Choreography: John Taras
**Music:* Igor Stravinsky (1945 version)
Costume and Set Design:
Geoffrey Holder
Costume Execution:
Grace Costumes, Inc.
Lighting: Clarke W. Thornton

This production was made possible by a generous gift from Mrs. Samuel P. Peabody and a grant from the Rockefeller Foundation.

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The Four Temperaments

Choreography: George Balanchine
**Music:* Paul Hindemith
Staged for DTH by Victoria Simon
Costumes: Zelda Wynn
Lighting: Clarke W. Thornton

This work for solo piano and strings together with the opera *L'Enfant et les Sortileges* by Ravel constituted the first Ballet Society (the direct predecessor of the New York City Ballet) program given on November 20, 1946. The popularity of this ballet has increased greatly in America and Europe through successive performances. It has always been a favorite of the dancers in the company.

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A Streetcar Named Desire

(Company Premiere January 14, 1982)

(Ballet based on the themes and characters of the play *A Streetcar Named Desire* by Tennessee Williams)

Choreography: Valerie Bettis
Music: Alex North
Sets Designed by Peter Larkin
Scenery Built and Painted by Merrill Stone Associates, Inc.
Costumes: Saul Bolasni
Costume Execution: Grace Costumes, Inc.
Lighting Designer: Clarke W. Thornton
Assistant to Miss Bettis: Robert Petersen

Place: The flat of Stanley Kowalski in the French Quarter during the late spring, summer, early fall of 1949. The action of the ballet shifts between the present, and the ever-recurring memories of Blanche's past.

A Synoposis of the Play

This is the haunting story of a beautiful girl who was betrayed by love. Blanche Dubois, tormented by the memory of her tragic marriage, the loss of her family home, and the subsequent scandal she has precipitated in the small Southern town of her birth, flees to New Orleans to find refuge with her sister. But, her sensual, crude brother-in-law resents her presence, and in a violent, passionate rage, exposes her past and cuts off her last chance of escape from the squalid misery of her life.

The original ballet was created for the Slavenska-Franklin Ballet Company in 1954, and this production has been recreated especially for the Dance Theatre of Harlem.

THIS PRODUCTION WAS DEDICATED TO MR. TENNESSEE WILLIAMS IN HONOR OF HIS 70TH BIRTHDAY.

Miss Bettis wishes to thank Frederic Franklin (the original Stanley) and Miss Carole Ann Lewis for their enthusiastic support and help in this production.

This production was made possible by a generous gift from Mrs. Samuel P. Peabody and a grant from the National Endowment for the Arts.

Troy Game

Choreography: Robert North
**Music:* Bob Downes
Assistant to Choreographer: Namron
Costumes: Peter Farmer
Costume Execution: Zelda Wynn
Lighting: Clarke W. Thornton
Percussionists:
The DTH Percussion Ensemble

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Paquita

Choreography: Marius Petipa
Staged by Alexandra Danilova and Frederic Franklin
Music by Ludwig Minkus and Edouard Deldevez
Costume Design and Execution: Carl Michell
Lighting: Clarke W. Thornton

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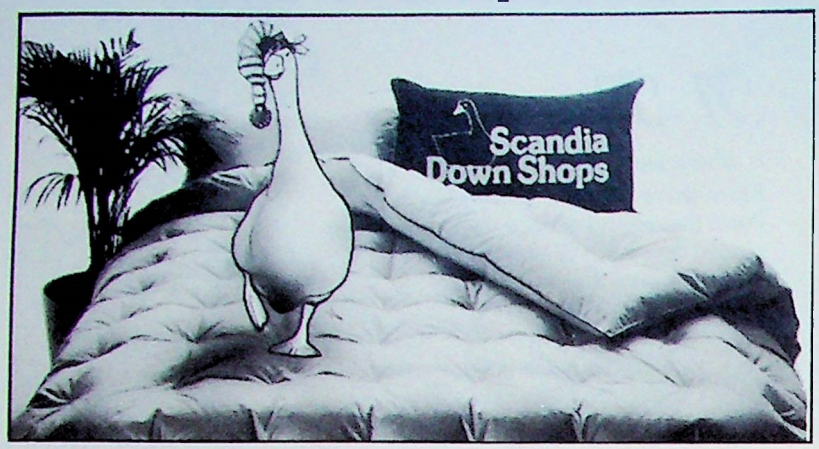
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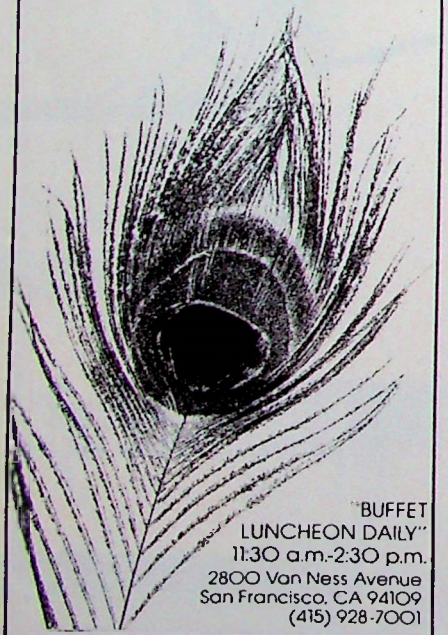
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continued from p. 12

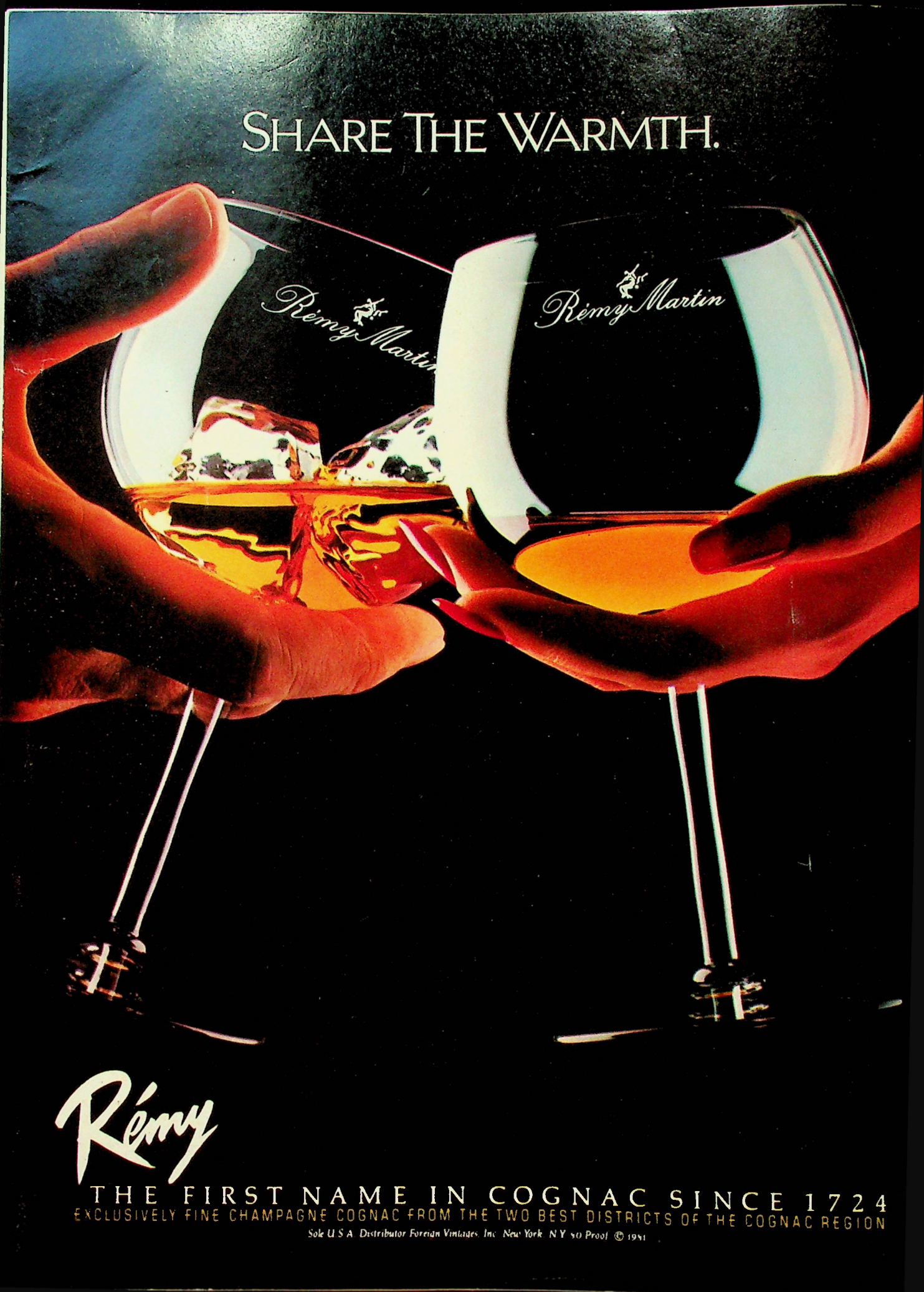
It is the phantasmagoria that Mr. Reiter-Soffer conveys so powerfully. The body-language style of the psychiatrist's role is too conventional to interest us in his own personality. But when the choreographer brings on Mr. Williams and five men — faces and thighs painted gold, pawing the earth and knees high, with fists in the small of their backs — the image is staggering. It is the age-old erotic image associated with the stallion. In the flames that envelop the scene in which the horses roll blinded on the floor, the choreographer, aided throughout by Wilfred Joseph's score, achieves a moment of terrible beauty. The other episodes are not on this level, but again certain performances are outstanding — D'Artagnan Perry as the boy, Alan, and Karlya Shelton as the stable girl, Jill.

Miss Bettis' 1952 dance version of *A Streetcar Named Desire* was originally danced by the ballet stars Mia Slavenska and Frederic Franklin. As the present Stanley, Mr. Smith is hardly a slouch. Casualness and strength, contempt and desire are conveyed in his every move. Nonetheless, the work remains a very 1950's translation of modern-dance concepts into ballet.

Alex North's vibrant jazz score introduces Peter Larkin's seedy house-stoop-and-interior décor. A set of shuttered windows suggests the stifling atmosphere in which Virginia Johnson's delicate Blanche first encounters Stanley in a theatrically red windbreaker. A figure in black lurks on the ground in a modern-dance style as a death symbol. Miss Bettis tells her tale in such symbols and short takes. Her forte is terseness in establishing characterization and relationships. A sexy embrace between Stanley and his wife informs Blanche of the tone of her sister's marriage. Blanche's classical solo is meant to convey her primness.

Less persuasive is the 1950's symbolism embodied in the death chorus of women on toe who accompany Blanche's flashbacks. Such touches are intercut with the present — Stanley taking Blanche's hankie to wipe his sweat, the sexual climate around Blanche, a blazingly danced cardgame by Mr. Smith (leaping high and landing softly) with Mr. Williams and Sulpicio Mariano. Even less strong is Blanche's encounter with the phantoms of her past — her husband and his lover. The story is cleverly condensed, the choreography not always varied enough. But in pure dramatic action — as in Stanley's pursuit of Blanche — Miss Bettis and the DTH dancers know how to pack a real wallop. ■

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